Martin later revealed that he bought eight litres of petrol, using a part of it—a litre each in the four bombs—to create a blaze for maximum damage.

Martin's demeanour initially put off the police, and the idea that a Christian sect's internal dissensions could end in a bomb blast seemed so out of whack—there really was no precedent. They treated him as a crank out to get media publicity. "He reached the Kodakara police station on a scooter and waited for 15 minutes," says Ajithkumar. "He told the civil police officer that he was behind the Kalamassery blasts. When the officer tried to shoo him away, he showed him videos of the blast on his mobile. We immediately took him into custody." According to the police, Martin has been "composed and cooperative throughout", answering all queries.

The suspect, who lives in Thammanam in Kochi with his wife and daughter, was working as construction foreman in Dubai. He has a son studying in London. Martin and his family were regulars at the JW Bible study sessions till about four years ago. "His wife says she had no idea about his anger against the church. The man has no history of violence," says a police officer who interrogated the family and neighbours. "His Google search history suggests he had researched about bomb-making. We also recovered bills for the petrol and the batteries used for the remote."

Trying to explain the event, a retired top police officer says, "Kerala has rarely seen bomb blasts despite being pictured in the media as a centre of Islamic terror after the ISIS episode (21 people from the state migrated to Afghanistan to join the terror outfit between 2016 and 2018). This handiwork of a maverick is a warning for all of us." An in-depth investigation should reveal whether anyone other than "lone wolf" Martin was involved. Meanwhile, the state government has acted swiftly to nip any ripple effect acts of violence in the bud, and reassure citizens that they are safe. But the scars from Kalamassery will take time to heal. ■

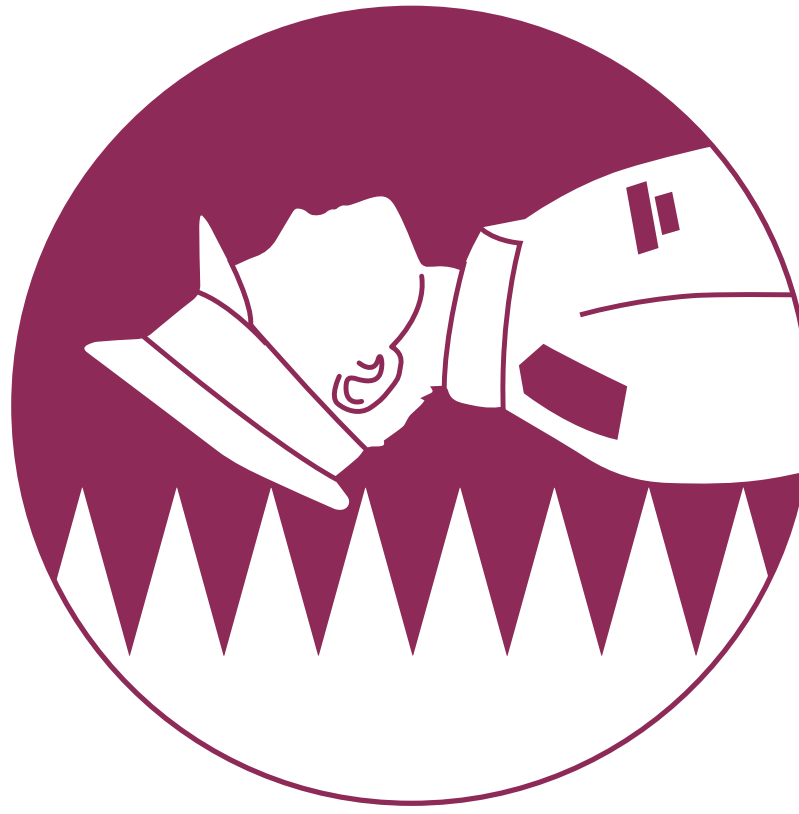


Illustration by TANMOY CHAKRABORTY

INDIANS ON DEATH ROW

BELEAGUERED IN QATAR

By Pradip R. Sagar

India had already been walking a difficult tight-rope on West Asian politics, roiled by the conflict in Gaza, when Qatar served a shocker on it on October 26: it awarded the death sentence to eight former Indian navy personnel on charges of spying for Israel. The decision, to which New Delhi responded with dismay and by cranking into motion the usual diplomatic machinery of damage limitation, marked a surprisingly sharp low turn in bilateral ties that are otherwise known to be robust. The external affairs ministry, which said it was "deeply shocked by the verdict of the death penalty", has vowed to mount a full-blown legal challenge against it, while working to secure the release of the eight ex-navymen. Employed with the private firm Al Dahra Global Technologies and Consultancy Services, they were overseeing the induction of stealth submarines for the Qatari navy. They have been under detention in separate locations in Doha since August 2022.

Qatar has so far not made any public statements about the trial conducted by its Court of First Instance. In fact, the charges were never made public, not even conveyed to the family members of the naval personnel. Some reports suggest secret details of Qatar's stealth submarine programme were leaked to Israel and the Indians were convicted on espionage charges linked to that. Al Dahra, established in 2014, is owned by Khamis Al